

Questions Matter

You’ve set up the tool: the app, the model, the effort dial, even what it remembers about you. None of it pays off until the moment this lesson is about: what you actually ask.

AI makes answers cheap. That does not make humans less valuable. It changes *where* value lives.

When anyone can get a fast answer, the edge shifts to the person who can ask the better question.

THE SHIFT

ANSWERS WERE EXPENSIVE

Old world

- Finding information took time
- Expertise was partly about access
- Producing a first draft was a big part of the job
- Summarizing and rewriting filled hours

ANSWERS ARE CHEAP

AI world

- First drafts are instant
- Summaries are instant
- Ideas are abundant
- Information is easier to access

WHERE VALUE MOVES

New scarcity

- Framing the problem
- Setting constraints
- Defining what good looks like
- Asking the next question

BEFORE AI

Question → Hours of work → Expensive answer

WITH AI

Question → Instant answer

Because answers are cheap, better questions become the advantage.

SAME AI. DIFFERENT QUESTION. DIFFERENT RESULT.

Two students ask about the same topic. One gets a textbook paragraph. The other gets something they can actually use.

WEAK QUESTION

“Tell me about climate change.”

BETTER QUESTION

“I’m a high school student preparing for a class debate. Give me the 3 strongest arguments for carbon taxes, the 3 strongest arguments against them, and tell me which side has the stronger evidence.”

The second person gets more value not because the AI is smarter, but because the human asked a better question. It frames the task, takes a real position, and says what a useful answer looks like.

A better question doesn’t make the answer automatically true. It just makes the answer more focused, more useful, and easier to check.

WHAT A BETTER QUESTION DOES

The new-scarcity column deserves a closer look. Not prompt tricks: four things a well-framed question gives the AI to work with.

1 🎯 **Frames the problem**

Most bad AI output starts with a fuzzy question. Naming what actually needs to be solved is half the work.

2 🛠️ **Sets constraints**

“Do it well” isn’t a spec. Deciding the audience, the format, the limits, and what to leave out shapes everything that comes back.

3 🏁 **Defines success**

Before you ask, know what a good answer looks like. Without that, you can’t tell whether the output is useful or just fluent.

4 ➡️ **Creates the next move**

A good question asks for something you can use, test, revise, or decide from. Not just something fluent to read.

🔑 **The advantage no longer goes to whoever produces the fastest first answer.** It goes to the person who frames the problem, sets the standard, and asks the next better question.